Crowbar Evaltree Insights

AI Safety — **2025 Edition**

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Executive Summary

AI safety in 2025 refers to technical and organizational practices designed to reduce risks from artificial intelligence systems. These risks range from model outputs that contain harmful content or misinformation, to broader concerns about autonomous systems acting in ways misaligned with human intent.

The field has moved from theoretical discussion to regulatory action. The European Union's AI Act entered into force in August 2024 and began phased implementation. The United States issued its Executive Order on Safe, Secure, and Trustworthy Artificial Intelligence in October 2023, establishing reporting requirements for frontier AI developers. China, the United Kingdom, India, and other jurisdictions have introduced guidelines, standards, or binding rules.

Key themes in 2025 include the operationalization of risk-based regulatory frameworks, increased transparency requirements for foundation model developers, growing attention to dual-use risks from publicly available models, and divergence between jurisdictions on how to classify and govern AI systems.

This brief synthesizes public information on what AI safety means, what risks regulators and researchers identify, what rules currently exist, and what organizations are doing in response. It is not advice and takes no position on policy outcomes.

What Is AI Safety (Plain English)

AI safety is the practice of building, deploying, and governing AI systems to reduce the probability and severity of harmful outcomes. The term encompasses technical research, engineering practices, organizational governance, and regulatory compliance.

Scope

AI safety includes model alignment (ensuring AI systems behave as intended), robustness (resistance to adversarial inputs or distributional shift), interpretability (understanding why models produce specific outputs), and misuse prevention (reducing the risk that capable systems are used for harmful purposes).

It also includes concerns about systemic risks such as economic disruption, the concentration of power, and long-term risks from highly capable autonomous systems. Different stakeholders emphasize different aspects. Regulators focus on near-term harms and accountability. Researchers emphasize technical challenges in aligning advanced models. Industry actors prioritize operational risk management and reputation.

Why the term **is often misunderstood**

AI safety is sometimes conflated with AI ethics, but the two are distinct. Ethics addresses values, fairness, and societal impact. Safety focuses on preventing specific harmful behaviors or failure modes. AI safety is also distinct from cybersecurity, though the two overlap when considering adversarial attacks on models.